The Apostles that Turned?

Authoritarian Successor Parties and Democratic Backsliding

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The Puzzle

- Authoritarian successor parties (ASPs) often credited with **stabilizing** young democracies
- **Optimistic account**: reinvented ASPs anchor democratic party systems Grzymala-Busse (2002, 2020); Miller (2021); Loxton & Mainwaring (2018); Riedl (2014)
- BUT, Hungary, Nicaragua, South Korea, Bolivia — ASPs as agents of democratic erosion
- **Research question:** When do ASPs undermine rather than support democracy?

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Argument: When Apostles Bite Back

- ASPs are vote-seeking organizations: survival drives behavior
- Electoral decline does not always produce dissolution; it can produce **adaptation/resistance**
- Reinvented ASPs have a readily available adaptive resource: the **authoritarian repertoire**
- When cornered, they revert to it: dog-whistling, anti-pluralism, and most importantly alliances with populists

Hypothesis

- The effect of reinvented ASPs on backsliding is conditional on anti-pluralism tendencies.
  - Anti-pluralism is an *indicator* of the underlying mechanism (not a direct cause)

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  - Populist outsiders can use ASPs' authoritarian repertoire to mobilize support
  - Populist ASPs restrict rivals' access to power

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  - Populist outsiders need institutional scaffolding & legitimacy (pull-factor)
  - Populist parties need institutional allies (push-factor)

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- Two-stage design:
  - **Cross-national**: Cox PH models (empirical scope calibration)
  - **Within-case**: Bayesian process tracing of South Korea (mechanism testing)
- Data: Grzymala-Busse (2020) $\times$ V-Party $\times$ ERT $\times$ V-Dem
- 81 countries, 1945–2015

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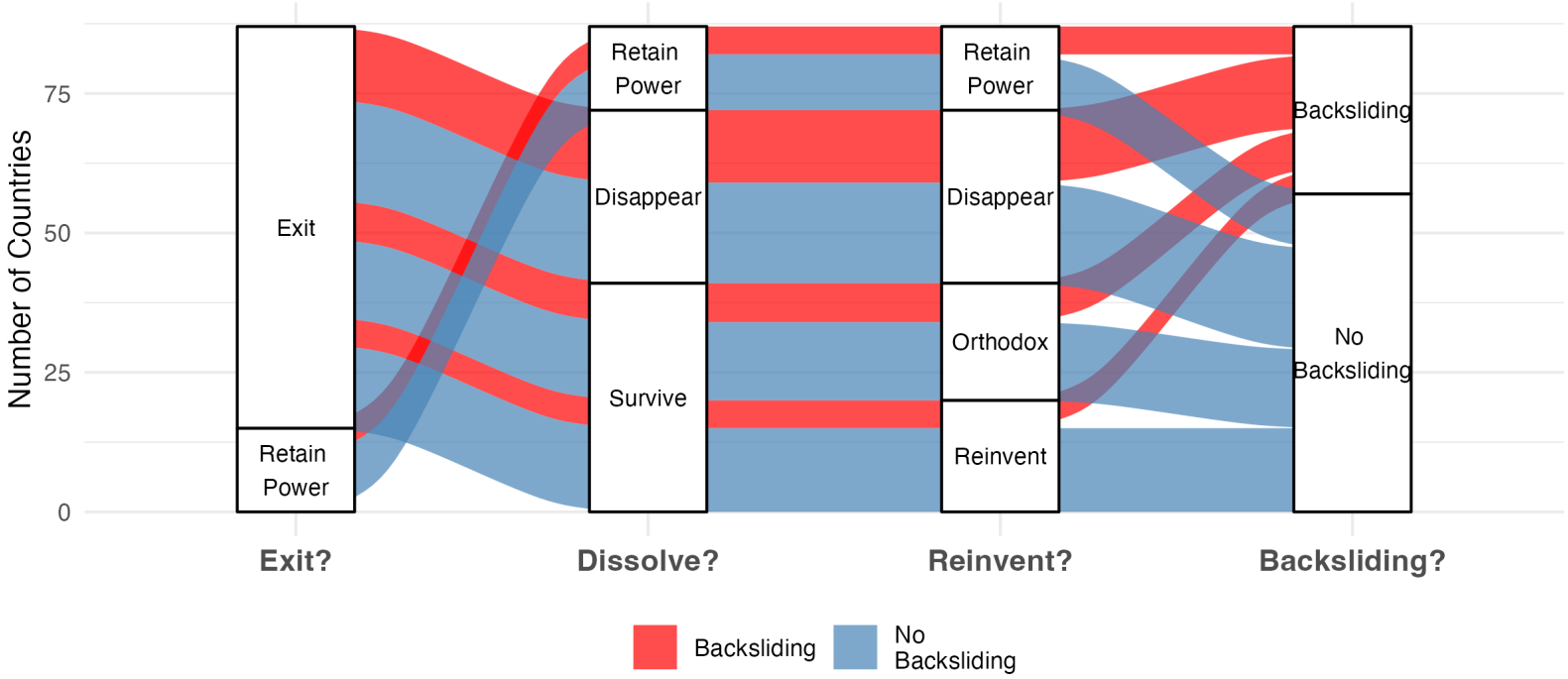
ASP Fate and Backsliding: Descriptive



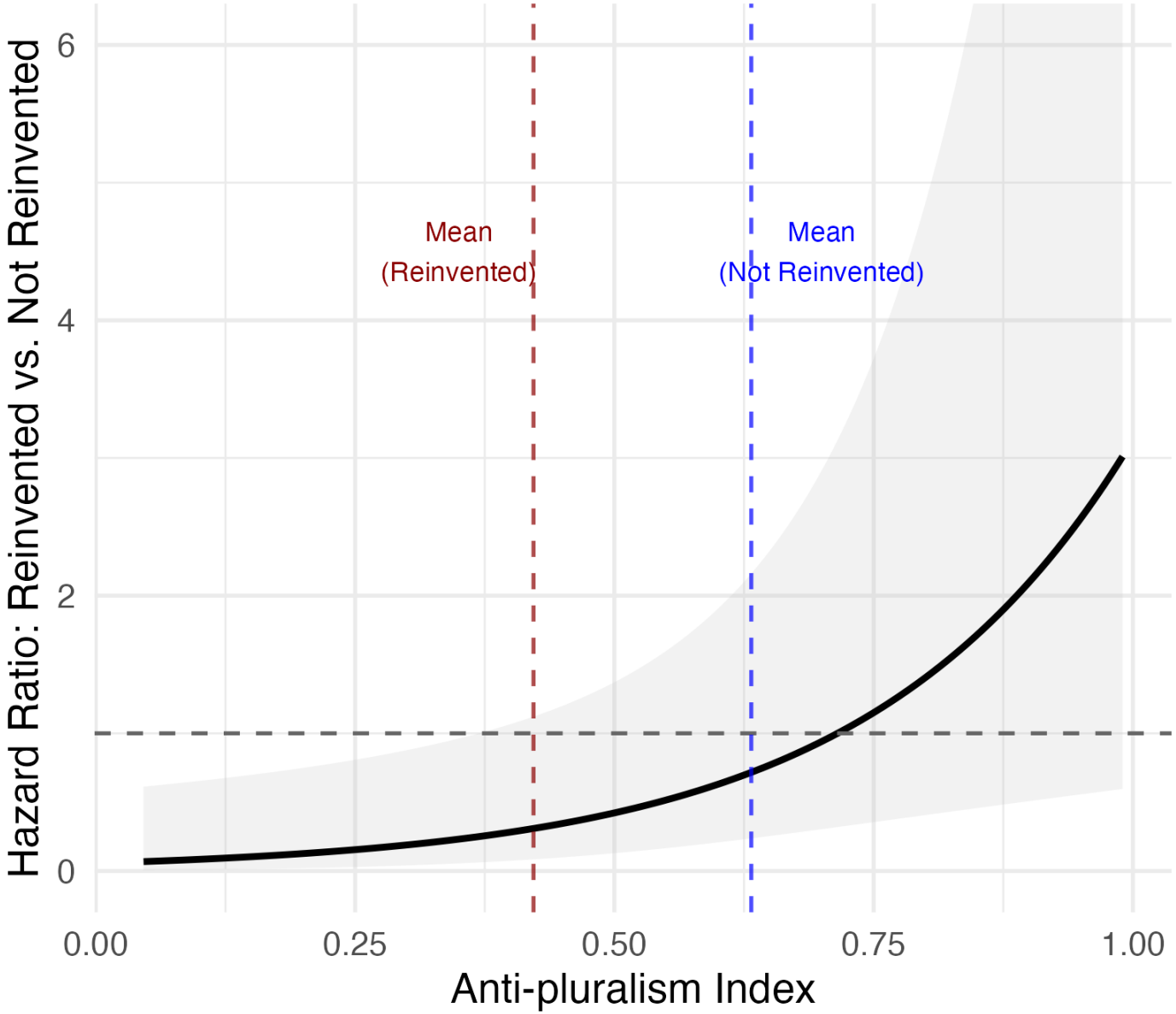
- Reinvented ASPs: minority of cases, non-negligible share of backsliding

Cox PH Estimates

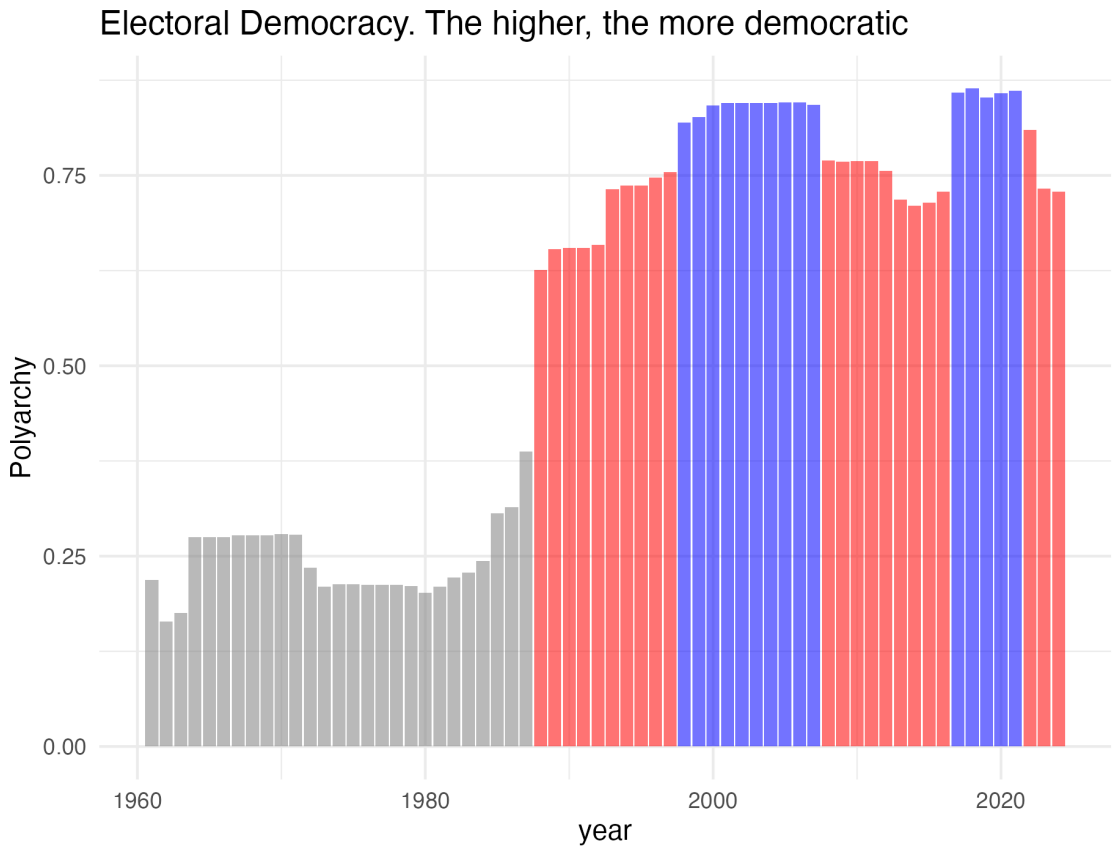
	Model 1 Baseline	**Model 2** Controls
Reinvented	0.057**	0.095*
	[0.005, 0.656]	[0.006, 1.446]
Anti-pluralism	0.479	0.593
	[0.060, 3.800]	[0.048, 7.384]
Reinvented × Anti-plur.	55.14**	192.51**
	[1.72, 1768]	[2.92, 12706]
Polyarchy		0.353
		[0.011, 11.3]
ln(GDP per capita)		0.419*
		[0.249, 0.708]
Num. Obs.	539	539
Concordance	0.703	0.769

Hazard ratios with 95% CI in brackets. SEs clustered by country.

Conditional Effect



Case: South Korea



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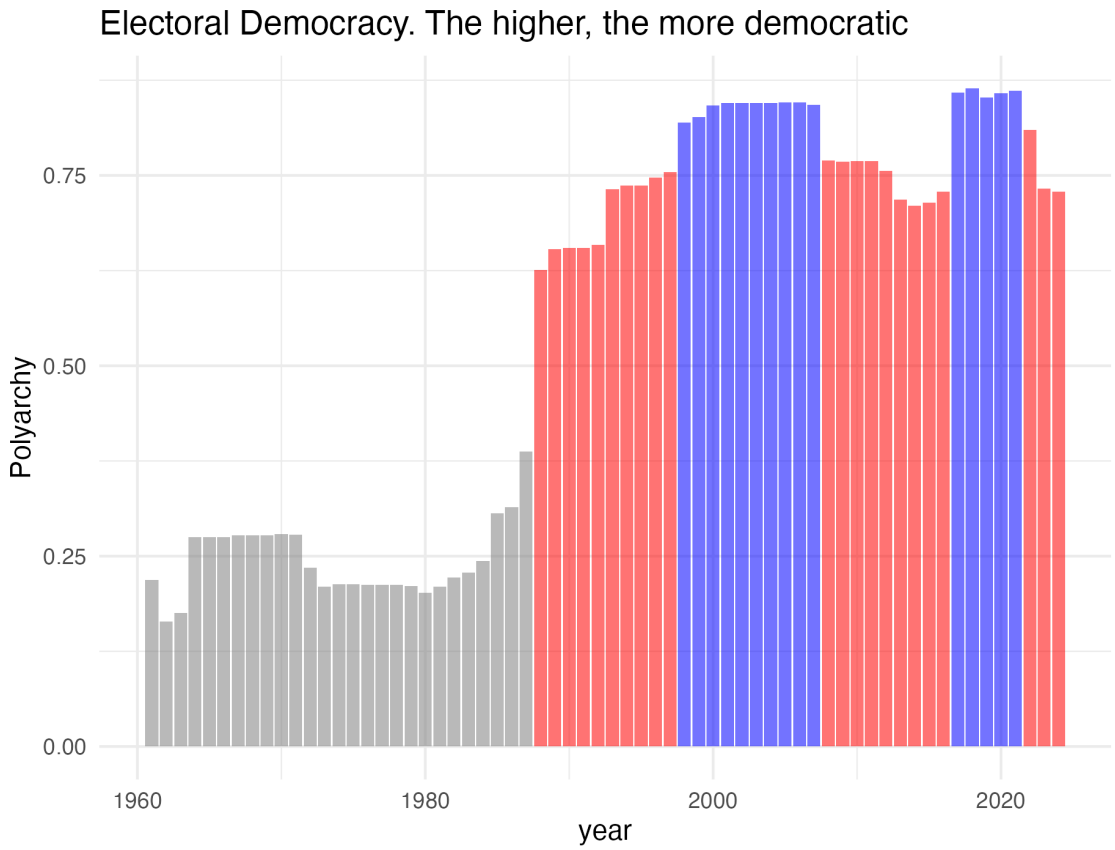

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Hypotheses and Priors

Hypothesis	Prior	Justification
H (Apostle)	0.40	Moderate cross-national support
A_1 (Demand-side: 'people wanted it')	0.35	Strong literature support; Korean value change plausible
A_2 (Institutional: 'Korean democracy weak')	0.25	Less applicable; presidential concentration

Summary of Evidential Tests I

OI	Type	Hypothesis	Predicted Evidence
H_1: Electoral Decline → Anti-pluralist Turn			
OI_1	Hoop	H_1	Decline precedes anti-pluralism rise
OI_2	Straw	H_1	Anti-pluralism follows electoral setbacks
OI_3	Smoking Gun	H_1	Elite decisions in response to decline
H_2: Anti-pluralist Turn → Facilitation of Outsider			
OI_4	Hoop	H_2	Anti-pluralism precedes alliance
OI_5	Smoking Gun	H_2	Outsider relies on ASP resources
OI_6	Doubly Decisive	H_2 vs. A_1	Outsider can't ascend without ASP
H_3: Alliance → Executive Aggrandizement			
OI_7	Hoop	H_3	Backsliding enabled by ASP presence
OI_8	Smoking Gun	H_3	Specific acts depend on ASP support
OI_9	Straw	H_3	Observers attribute to ASP facilitation
Alternative Hypotheses			
OI_{A1a}	Hoop for A_1	Against A_1	Voter anti-pluralism precedes party shift
OI_{A1b}	Discriminating	Against A_1	Party follows rather than leads voters
OI_{A2}	Discriminating	Against A_2	Non-ASP governments did not backslide

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Contribution

- Reconceptualizes ASPs as **conditionally** destabilizing
- Integrates party-level dynamics into backsliding theory
- Bridges two bodies of literature that have developed in isolation:
  - ASP / democratic consolidation
  - Contemporary democratic backsliding
- Policy implication: the most effective democratic gatekeepers can become its most dangerous saboteurs when cornered